

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD X

7-0 A

Red 12/10/00 upl

Species: Red-throated Loon (*Gavia stellata*)**Date:** 21 May 2000**Number seen:** one**Sex:** ?**Plumage:** Alternate**Locality:** John Martin Res.**Elevation:** 3851'**Nearest town:** Ft. Lyon**County:** Bent**Time observed:** late afternoon**Duration of observation:** about one minute

Description: While on a Big Day, Larry Semo and Chris Wood and I looked for the Alternate-plumaged Red-throated Loon that Brandon Percival had originally found in early May. I was scanning through the large number of Western and Clark's grebes that were mostly backlit and found the loon. We looked at it somewhat briefly, then departed to break the state record.

It was a small loon, being roughly the size of the Western Grebes present and with a roughly similar build (though being shorter-necked and chunkier than that species). Though I couldn't determine much in the way of plumage details due to the poor lighting, the bird had a dark neck, unlike the white necks of the Western Grebes; thus it was in Alternate plumage, not Basic. The bill was short and thin, much shorter than the bills of the grebes. The bird held its head angled slightly upward, such that the bill was above parallel to the water surface. The chest was white and the upperparts were dark.

Similar species eliminated by description: All other loons are readily eliminated by the bill size and shape and overall body size. The two large grebes are also easily ruled out by the lack of bold black-and-white coloration. Red-necked Grebe is eliminated by size (the bird was too large) and bill size and shape (the bill was too short and thin). Red-breasted Merganser is ruled out by head shape (no crest at all on the bird), bill shape, and body shape and size. All cormorants are eliminated by plumage pattern and/or size. No other species is at all similar.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): The bird was not heard.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing species? I have seen from three (Arctic) to 10s of 1000s (Red-throated and Common) of all loon species and have seen 10s of 1000s (Double-crested Cormorant) to uncountable bazillions (Red-breasted Merganser) of all other remotely-similar species.

Light conditions: sun was in front of me and slightly to my right

Optical equipment used: Leica 20-60x

Distance, and how estimated: estimated at 750 meters

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Chris Wood and Larry Semo

Other observers who saw the bird independently: numerous, including Brandon Percival and Mark Janos

If photographed, type of equipment and film: did not photograph

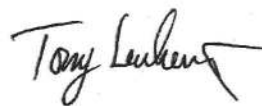
List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: none

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature:



Address: Colorado Bird Observatory, 13401 Picadilly Road, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: 10 December 2000 from brief notes that I wrote the following day